fact, he sang his compositions. As far as the history of Akbar is concerned, however, Baz Bahadur's pre-eminent contribution was to give the padishah – or his historians – the logic of his imperial design. Thus, writes Abul Fazl, the ruler of Malwa was 'immersed in bestial pleasures'. Or, as Nizamuddin puts it, 'Baz Bahadur had given himself up to sensuality, and cared nothing for the country'. To take that country from him, therefore, was only Akbar's duty; indeed, the emperor's 'justice' (Abul Fazl), the very 'honour of the imperial throne' (Nizamuddin) demanded conquest so that the dissolute sultan's wretched subjects might find 'peace and security'.[6]

Until now, Akbar's chieftains had fought to preserve their presence in Hindustan, battling to stay in place, more or less. Thus, Mirza Sharafuddin – now Akbar's brother-in-law – was off seizing forts in Rajasthan, while the lovelorn Ali Quli Shaibani was in Jaunpur battling Afghans with his usual flair. This was a tried-and-tested method of maintaining the momentum of a conquest while also maintaining the conquerors. The nascent Mughal 'empire' had no steady flow of revenue, but it did have warlords, none of whom were in the business for their health. Babur's solution to the problem was to assign territory to his commanders, 'often . . . resistant cities' from which they were to 'extract . . . their expenses for maintaining their soldiers, households and pleasures',[7] and send the rest back to the ostensibly 'imperial' treasury.

The conquest of Malwa, in the way that it is officially described, reversed this logic, in that its beneficiary was no longer the conqueror but the conquered – as, much like US marines transporting American democracy to the world, Akbar's troops now embraced the responsibility of foisting his justice upon the many kingdoms of Hindustan they would engulf.

They could not have had a more ironic start.

Adham Khan, Maham's son, was in command of the troops, with Pir Muhammad, Bairam Khan's arrogant deputy, by his side. The Mughal and Malwa armies met outside the town of Sarangpur. Every day, they skirmished without clear result; and every day, the Mughal troops sent scouting parties to spy on the enemy and block their access to grain. One day, these scouts were late returning and, losing their way in the dark, they rode right into the Malwa camp. A fast, furious and very unexpected battle later, Baz Bahadur was routed and fled.